The Fall of Han and the Rise of the Xin Dynasty

In the 9th century CE, Wang Mang overthrew the Han rulers, seized the throne and claimed the Mandate of Heaven for himself. He wanted to redistribute wealth among the peasants and the nobility. This was the foundation of Xin Dynasty, which lasted between 9 and 23 CE. The peasants supported him initially but the landowners disliked his policies. Despite his best intentions, the policies he strove to apply were not properly thought out. Unemployment and bitterness soon spread throughout the empire. The Yellow River flooded the land once again and the rebels created uprisings against the Emperor. It was not long before Wang Mang was slain by the same peasants he had overthrown the previous government for.

With the declaration of the Xin Dynasty came the end of what is regarded as the Western Han period. When the Xin Dynasty itself fell only a few years later, the Han rulers were reinstated. This generally marks the beginning of the Eastern Han period. The new emperor gave the previous landowners back their lands and brought peace to what had become a chaotic country. The old policies were reinstated but the emperor found himself constantly trying to prevent the uprisings in modern-day Korea and Vietnam. He was trying to ensure they remained under Chinese rule. In 39, CE, the Trung sisters led a revolt against the Chinese. The emperor was forced to send tens of thousands soldiers to subdue these rebels. Guang Wu was able to consolidate his authority in these areas and expanded the borders once more, which allowed trade to increase. When Emperor Zhang took the throne in 75 CE, the empire had amassed a great deal of wealth. The revenue came from extensive trading that was conducted between the Chinese and other civilizations such as the Roman Empire. Marcus Aurelius was a Roman Emperor who believed that silk was priceless and gave the Chinese traders whatever price they asked for. China took great advantage of other nations to build its economy during this time.

Despite the increase in prosperity, there were still some squabbles between the rich landowners and the peasantry. This led to what is called the Five Pecks of Rice Rebellion and the Yellow Turban Rebellions of 184 CE. The